THE FAMILY OF GOD · LESSON 1

The Father Who Never Gave Up

Romans 8:15 · Luke 15:11–32

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His love never stopped reaching.

> *"The Spirit you received brought about your adoption to sonship. And by him we cry, 'Abba, Father.'"*
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> ROMANS 8:15 · LUKE 15:11–32

We praise God "for the Son of Thy love." Over five Sundays we're looking at something that runs throughout the entire Bible: God's desire to have a relationship with us, not simply as our Creator, but as our Father. The Old Testament is a story of the distance God went to show us how much He loves us, and it leads to Jesus, the fullest revelation of the Father's love. But are we hearing what He has been saying since He walked in the garden? God didn't simply create a world He could rule. He created people He could love. Like the father in Luke 15, He gives us space, keeps the light shining, and welcomes us home, not as hired hands but as sons and daughters who cry, "Abba, Father." God didn't send Jesus simply to save us from something. He sent Jesus to bring us back to Someone.

1 Not Simply Our Creator, but Our Father

FOR THE SON OF THY LOVE

We praise God "for the Son of Thy love." Over the next five Sundays we're looking at something that runs throughout the entire Bible: God's desire to have a relationship with us. Not simply as our Creator, but as our Father. How far would you go to convince someone that you love them? The Old Testament reveals how far God was willing to go. It is a story of the distance God went to show us how much He loves us and how much we need our Creator. Throughout it God was patient, merciful, and gracious while He worked His plan, and the lesson wasn't just for the house of Israel. It was for humanity.

2 He Wants Us Home

THE FIRST RESPONDER

A firefighter rescues a child from a burning home. But what if the child inside that house were his own son or daughter? God doesn't simply want to rescue us. He wants us home. The Old Testament has its climax in the New: the Messiah arrives, only to be rejected. Jesus is God in the flesh. Humanity couldn't get the picture through mere words, so God came to model goodness, righteousness, compassion, and the love of a Father. Jesus is the fullest revelation of the Father's love. But have we fully taken in what God has been communicating?

3 Are We Hearing What God Is Saying?

IS WHAT I SAY WHAT PEOPLE HEAR?

Jefferson Fisher, a Texas trial attorney and author of The Next Conversation, asks, "Is what I say what people hear?" It's easy to look back and see that the Hebrews kept mishearing and misunderstanding God. But what are we hearing? What do you see when you see God creating man, or walking with Adam and Eve in the garden? From the beginning, God's desire was not merely to have people who would worship Him, but children who would know Him, love Him, and share in His life.

4 At the Heart of the Christian Story

JOHN 3:16 · ROMANS 5:8 · ROMANS 8:15

Humanity has developed many understandings of God. Judaism recognizes God as Father but does not accept Jesus as His divine Son. Islam rejects the idea that God has a Son. Hinduism and Buddhism understand ultimate reality very differently. But at the heart of Christianity is something extraordinary: God loves us so deeply that He gave His Son, not simply to save us, but to bring us into His family. The temple and the Ark were never God's ultimate vision of His presence; in the new covenant God lives in us, and the distance barrier has been removed. His motivation: He loved the world (John 3:16). His demonstration: while we were still sinners (Romans 5:8). His invitation: the Spirit of adoption (Romans 8:15). God didn't simply create a world He could rule. He created people He could love.

5 Keeping the Door Open

THE LIGHTHOUSE AND THE BRIDGE

What would it take for us to truly believe that a relationship with God as His son or daughter is better than anything out there? Why is that so hard to believe? Jefferson Fisher says loving parents keep the door open. Our beliefs have deep roots, and turning someone around can take a long time. When you can't be a bridge, be a lighthouse. He was talking about earthly parents, but it sounds like our Father. A lighthouse doesn't force anyone to come home. It simply keeps shining so they can find their way back. God wants to close the gap between us and Him. The lighthouse helps us find our way, but the bridge allows us to come home.

6 The Father Never Gave Up

LUKE 15 · ROMANS 8:15–16

The son took his inheritance, and the father gave him space. Love doesn't always prevent someone from walking away. Sometimes we have to remember the goodness of the Father before we're willing to return to Him. The father didn't make the inheritance the issue; the relationship mattered more. The son came home looking for a place to work. The father welcomed him back as a son. The Bible is the story of a Father restoring His family: created for fellowship, broken by sin, the way prepared in the Old Testament, and the welcome home through Jesus. Paul doesn't merely say we belong to God. He says we can cry out, "Abba, Father." We don't simply recognize God as our Creator. We come to know Him as our Father.

QUOTES

God doesn't simply want our obedience. He wants our hearts.

God didn't send Jesus simply to save us from something. He sent Jesus to bring us back to Someone.

The greatest gift God offers us isn't simply a place in heaven. It's a place in His family.